

4.6 Assessment criteria for improvised performances

Holistic assessment criterion

'Errors' may result from playing or singing the stimulus material wrongly, or they may be notes which are obviously wrong in the context of the chosen style.

Holistic (AO1)		
36–40	Outstanding	Impressive and imaginative: the student has stamped their personal musical authority on the performance. Complete (or almost complete) control of technique, style and interpretation. Sense of musical wholeness with no passage sub-standard.
31–35	Excellent	Convincing throughout: and an engaging performance. Secure technique and sensitivity of style and interpretation. Any errors and/or misjudgements are marginal.
26–30	Confident	Convincing for most of the time in technique, style and interpretation. Secure technique and sensitive interpretation. Some errors and/or misjudgements, but too few to have a big impact.
21–25	Competent	Generally secure and conscientious in technique and interpretation. Some errors and/or misjudgements, but the piece still has some direction and flow.
16–20	Adequate	A serious attempt but probably a performance with limited maturity and assurance. Some control of technique and interpretation. Errors, misjudgements and technical problems begin to be obtrusive, but the performance still broadly holds together.
11–15	Basic	Positive features are fairly few with the performance inconsistent and/or immature. Basic technical control, fluency and accuracy and a basic understanding of interpretative issues. Errors, misjudgements and technical problems are obtrusive.
6–10	Limited	Positive features are few. A few encouraging signs, but considerable difficulties with a weak performance in most areas. Perhaps under the required length.
1–5	Poor	Positive features are very few, being heavily outweighed by errors, misjudgements and technical problems. In practice, a mark in the 1–5 band is appropriate only for work which is seriously under the required performance length and/or difficulty or too incomplete to be marked using the five detailed assessment criteria.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Detailed assessment criteria

Criterion 1: Quality of outcome Overall security and effectiveness of the performance.
Interpretation and musical communication. Extent to which the piece meets the specification in terms of duration.

The text in *italics* refers to ensemble performances only.

Criterion 1: Quality of outcome (AO1)		
8	Outstanding	Mature, exciting and imaginative interpretation with a strong sense of authority and musical communication. <i>Consistently responsive reaction to other parts and if necessary adjustment to them. Thorough awareness of balance.</i>
7	Excellent	Sensitive interpretation, with a good sense of style and musical communication. <i>Excellent reaction to other parts and if necessary adjustment to them. Good awareness of balance throughout.</i>
6	Confident	Confident (if not always subtle) interpretation, but consistent, and with fairly good musical communication. <i>Generally good reaction to other parts and if necessary adjustment to them. Good awareness of balance throughout.</i>
5	Competent	Broadly satisfying interpretation with a few weaknesses not seriously detracting from the overall impression — but with limited success in musical communication. <i>Generally reasonably good reaction to other parts and some ability to adjust to them if necessary, but also a few difficulties. Some awareness of balance throughout.</i>
4	Adequate	Serious attempt at interpretation, but some obvious technical weaknesses and/or inconsistency, or very mechanical. <i>Some ability to react to other parts and adjust to them if necessary, but with clear difficulties. At least some awareness of balance throughout.</i>
3	Basic	Reasonable attempt (eg in isolated expressive passages), but marred by technical problems or brevity. <i>Some basic ability to react to other parts, but with clear difficulties, and probably little ability to adjust. At least some awareness of balance throughout.</i>
2	Limited	Limited sense of assurance and seriously compromised by lack of sophistication, accuracy, and/or brevity. <i>Limited ability to react to other parts. There are numerous difficulties, and probably little or no ability to adjust. Limited awareness of balance.</i>
1	Poor	Very little evidence of competence. Seriously under-length. <i>There are numerous difficulties and very little evidence of reaction to other parts. Little or no awareness of balance.</i>
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 2: Using the stimulus

Accuracy in playing or singing the stimulus material. Exploitation and development of the stimulus.

Criterion 2: Using the stimulus (AO1)		
8	Outstanding	An accurate performance of the stimulus. Ambitious and highly creative realisation of the stimulus throughout — highly imaginative.
7	Excellent	An accurate performance of the stimulus. Ambitious and creative realisation of the stimulus throughout.
6	Confident	An accurate performance of the stimulus apart, for example, from one or two very slight errors. Ambitious and creative realisation of the stimulus, with only occasional weaknesses.
5	Competent	An accurate performance of the stimulus apart, for example, from one or two very slight errors. Broadly satisfying realisation of the stimulus with a few weaknesses not seriously detracting from the overall impression.
4	Adequate	An accurate or broadly accurate performance of the stimulus. Serious attempt at using and developing the stimulus, despite some obvious technical weaknesses, or mechanical end product.
3	Basic	At least some accuracy in performing the stimulus but there may be obvious errors. Reasonable attempt to use and develop the stimulus, but marred by technical problems or brevity.
2	Limited	Probably limited accuracy in performing the stimulus, with obvious errors. Limited use and development of the stimulus, seriously compromised by lack of sophistication and/or brevity
1	Poor	Very little accuracy in performing or developing the stimulus. Seriously under-length.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

**Criterion 3:
Coherence**

Structure: sense of wholeness (including relationship between component parts and the whole), and structure of individual sections. Balance of unity and variety.

Criterion 3: Coherence (A01)		
8	Outstanding	Imaginative, with sophisticated and/or complex structure. Completely convincing balance between unity and variety.
7	Excellent	A sense of wholeness, with sophisticated and/or complex structure. Convincing balance between unity and variety.
6	Confident	Some feeling of wholeness, with sophisticated and/or complex structure. Generally convincing balance between unity and variety, despite a few minor misjudgements.
5	Competent	Satisfactory use of basic, balanced structures. Some balance between unity and variety, despite minor misjudgements.
4	Adequate	Serious attempt at using basic, balanced structures, but repetitive, predictable or formulaic. Serious attempt to create variety, but repetitive or lacking contrast in parts.
3	Basic	Basic sense of structure, but repetitive, predictable and/or formulaic. Some attempt to create variety.
2	Limited	A limited sense of structure, design and balance, lacking flow and contrast.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of structure, design or balance.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 4: Tone and technique

Quality of instrumental or vocal sound ('tone quality'). Intonation and other aspects of instrumental or vocal technique (bowing, pedalling, etc as appropriate).

Criterion 4: Tone and technique (AO1)		
8	Outstanding	Impressive tone quality throughout the pitch range. Thorough technical control. Intonation completely secure.
7	Excellent	Good tone quality throughout the pitch range. Very good technical control. Intonation secure, despite one or two slightly out-of-tune notes.
6	Confident	Good tone quality throughout the pitch range, except for at the extremities or at moments of technical difficulty. Generally good technical control. Intonation secure, despite a few slightly out-of-tune notes.
5	Competent	Good tone quality across most of the pitch range. Fairly good technical control, but occasional technical weaknesses. Intonation reasonably secure, despite some noticeably out-of-tune notes.
4	Adequate	Generally acceptable tone quality, although occasionally dull. Some technical control, but problems begin to be obtrusive. Intonation sometimes secure, but several patches are weak.
3	Basic	Tone quality acceptable at times, but often dull, thin or coarse Technical control still evident at times, but there are significant problems. Intonation rarely secure or consistently sharp/flat.
2	Limited	Tone quality acceptable occasionally, but mostly dull, thin or coarse. Technical control only very intermittent. Intonation scarcely ever secure and likely to be inconsistent.
1	Poor	Very little control of tone or technique. Intonation severely deficient virtually throughout.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 5: Use of resources

Handling of instrument or voice. Range of timbres (where appropriate). Choice and management of textures.

Criterion 5: Use of resources (A01)		
8	Outstanding	Imaginative with full understanding and thoughtful exploitation of the instrument/voice. Imaginative use of an appropriate range of textures.
7	Excellent	Very good understanding and exploitation of the instrument/voice. A range of appropriate textures handled very successfully.
6	Confident	Generally effective with some attempt to exploit the instrument/voice. Range of textures handled securely with only a few minor misjudgements.
5	Competent	Broadly satisfying although not much attempt to extend the instrument/voice. Textures generally well handled, but a little lacking in variety.
4	Adequate	Rather functional treatment of the instrument/voice. Textures reasonably well handled, but probably lacking in variety.
3	Basic	Some basic ability in handling the instrument/voice, but with some unidiomatic writing. Textures sometimes misjudged and/or unvaried.
2	Limited	Limited awareness of instrumental/vocal idiom or texture (probably with some unplayable/unsingable material).
1	Poor	Very little evidence of good judgement in handling instrument/voice and textures.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 6: The performance as a whole

Overall musical impression. Structure and planning of programme.

Criterion 6: The performance as a whole (A01)		
10	Outstanding	Very impressive musically. A striking performance throughout. Highly imaginative choice of programme. Pieces in an entirely suitable order. Planning shows great care and thoroughness.
9	Excellent	Very good musically. Imaginative choice of programme. Pieces in an entirely suitable order. Planning shows care and thoroughness.
8	Confident	Good musically, apart from a few minor lapses. Well-considered choice of programme. Pieces in a suitable order. Planning careful and generally effective.
7	Competent	Good musically, apart from a few lapses. Generally well-considered choice of pieces. Pieces in a generally suitable order. Planning generally careful and mostly effective.
6	Adequate	Secure musically and broadly successful, but a little short of musical interest Some care in choosing the programme, but there may be some lack of contrast or coherence. Order of pieces is a little illogical. Planning shows some care.
5	Basic	Solid musically and broadly successful, but lacking in real musical interest. Some care in choosing the programme, but lack of real contrast and/or coherence. Order of pieces fails to convince. Some basic planning has taken place.
3-4	Limited	Limited musical interest, perhaps because the performance is under-length. Limited thought given to choosing the programme, with lack of contrast and/or little coherence. Pieces in more or less random order. Little evidence of careful planning.
1-2	Poor	A performance with very few musical merits, perhaps partly because it is under-length. More or less random collection of pieces. Very little evidence of planning.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	